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Fig. 2: LTE connects M2M applications through long-range connections that enable low latency and high-bandwidth connections (Courtesy: <http://shahneil.com>)

them well suited to mass M2M deployments which older networks are not able to support.

Superior performance. For M2M applications that require higher speeds and better responsiveness, LTE is an ideal solution.

Overcoming barriers to LTE adoption

Barriers for LTE adoption to M2M applications include a heavy hardware price premium in the M2M sector that is price-sensitive, and band fragmentation that adds to the cost and complexity. LTE also provides a dynamic data coverage with high bandwidth for applications that are often mission specific and do not require more bandwidth.

The cost of LTE modules and devices will go down in time, as is the case with all new technologies. Lack of LTE coverage in some areas will also be resolved as LTE deployments proceed around the globe.

Enhancement of LTE for M2M

Engineers are developing a new LTE broadcasting scheme that would allow the network to prevent all low-priority devices from accessing the network during certain time frames. Standard groups are working with LTE technology developers to create standards to

protect the network from congestion or failures from roaming connections. This would be important for assuring that if there are multiple networks located in a single location, a failure in one network would not immediately lead to a huge spike in traffic (and potentially even a failure) in the other.

Optimising LTE for M2M

Following options can be considered to optimise LTE for M2M:

1. Developing a new class of low-cost, low-speed LTE devices
2. Reducing congestion caused by large-scale M2M deployments
3. Minimising the footprint of LTE devices accessing the network
4. Improving power efficiency with longer sleep cycles for latency-tolerant applications and configurable mobility-management functions

The high-speed and performance-based M2M applications are rapidly supporting LTE whilst others would soon converge their paths. The advantages of LTE are simply too great for M2M stakeholders to ignore for the IoT. ●

The author is a technical journalist at EFY, Gurgaon. (Key inputs from the 'LTE—Delivering on the mobile broadband promise' white paper by Charles Sturman, product manager-LTE-Chips, u-blox, Ezra Stein, product manager-LTE-Modules, u-blox, and Carl Fenger, product communications manager, u-blox)